
On the Review Process and Journal Development

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ABSTRACT This paper describes the editorial and review process currently operating at *JMS* and offers the Editors' perspective on the journal's growth over the past three years. We first outline what we think is the essence of a *JMS* article. Then, we describe the review process from the editor's initial decision, to the reviewers' comments, to the editor's final editorial decisions, and including the process of accepting a paper. We suggest four main reasons for rejecting a paper: lack of contribution, failure to develop a theoretical contribution, fatal flaws in methods and deficiencies in analysis. With respect to the journal's progress, we show that *JMS* has significantly increased its position in the ISI rankings to 19th and its impact factor to 1.180. In addition, the journal experienced a 222 per cent increase in submissions from 2003 to 2005.

INTRODUCTION

Three years ago, as the *Journal of Management Studies* (*JMS*) entered its 40th year of publication, Timothy Clark and Mike Wright took over as General Editors. In 2004 they were joined by Steve Floyd as a fellow General Editor. In this article, we set out what we hope will be some useful pointers relating to the *JMS* review process and policies more generally, and we take stock of a number of *JMS* developments after our first three years. In the process we hope to provide answers to the questions we are most frequently asked when participating in panels or colloquia at conferences.

WHAT MAKES A *JMS* ARTICLE?

JMS was launched 43 years ago, making it the oldest general management journal outside of North America. The current editors have maintained the Journal's original inclusive ethos. We attach no priority to the subject of a study. Instead, we seek papers that are innovative and novel. Similarly, we are open to a wide range

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of methodological approaches and philosophical underpinnings. Whatever methodological approach is adopted, however, it is important that it suits the topic and research questions and that it be rigorously executed. Finally, we expect that the goal of most papers will be to make a theoretical contribution to the field of management studies. Overall, the content areas covered by *JMS* are very wide and of interest to a broad range of research areas, disciplines and scholars. The Aims of the Journal are published inside the front cover of every issue.

We recognize that the Journal is primarily read by academics. Nevertheless, the contents of the Journal inform practice in a number of ways, including through the teaching and consultancy work undertaken by academics who read the Journal. We are also aware that what is published in *JMS* influences ideas that reach practitioners through textbooks and other media. Authors, therefore, should think carefully about what a manager or organization might do differently based on the argument or findings in their paper.

THE REVIEW PROCESS

The decision making process for articles submitted to the Journal is illustrated in Figure 1. This presents the various stages that an article can go through as well as

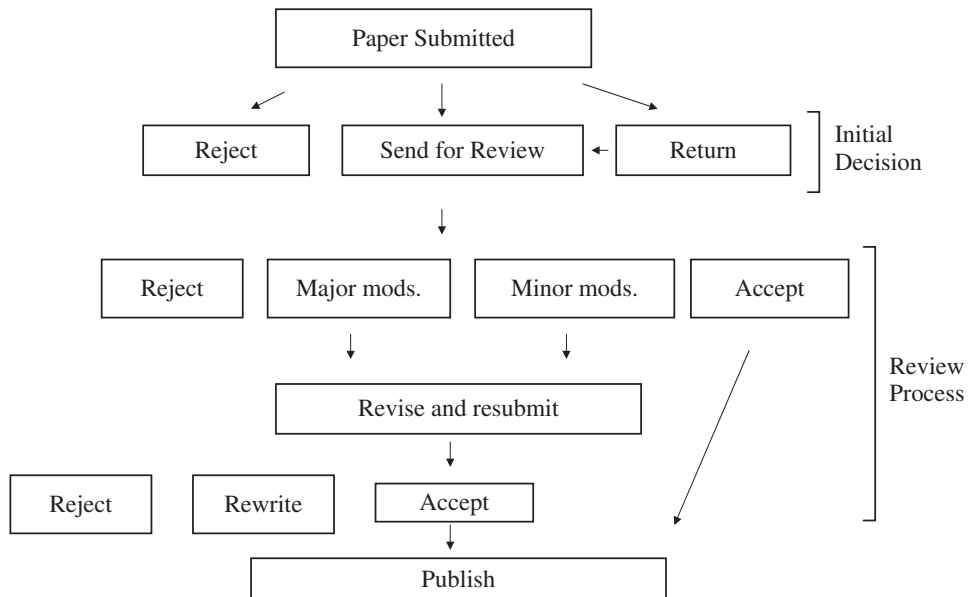


Figure 1. Stages and alternative decisions in the review process
 Mods = moderations.

the range of decisions available. Whatever the decision and stage, it is our intention that all authors receive detailed and helpful feedback that assists them in developing their paper.

The Initial Decision

When a paper is received by the Editorial Office it is allocated to one of the three General Editors by matching the topic with their areas of expertise. They then have responsibility for deciding whether to send the paper out for review. Of the 1,316 papers submitted to the Journal over the three-year period 2003–05, 50 per cent were sent out for review and a further 3 per cent were returned to the authors for revision before being sent out to reviewers. In the latter cases, papers were returned so that authors could do things such as: remove author-identifying information from the article, reduce the word count so that it falls within word limits (9,000 words), correct grammatical and typographical mistakes, insert missing references, clarify certain concepts and areas and further develop the contribution of the paper. In returning a paper at this stage, our intention is to eradicate minor issues that may come up in the review process. On average over the three year period 2003–05, it took 12 days to decide whether to send a paper out to review or not. For the 47 per cent of papers not sent out to review, we endeavour to provide constructive feedback outlining the reasons for our decision and suggesting ways forward.

Articles may be withheld from the peer review process for a number of reasons. Although the journal is broad in scope and inclusive, some papers do not fall within its domain. Typically, these articles are not relevant to our management studies audience because they are written with another discipline or audience in mind. For example, the fields of micro-organizational behaviour and organizational psychology overlap. Both make valuable contributions. On occasion, however, we receive articles in the area of organizational psychology that offer little or no link to the general management literature. If an article does not connect to management studies, it may be more appropriate for a specialist journal. Other articles are rejected without review because they are suited more to an applied journal.

Many articles are initially rejected by the editors because, while being well-executed, they simply replicate prior research in a different context. We welcome articles from non-US and non-UK contexts. We want to emphasize, however, that simply demonstrating that a particular theory is or is not applicable in a new context usually offers too little contribution to be publishable in *JMS*. The key to making a contribution in such cases is to explain why the theory is/is not applicable, and on this basis, to extend the theory in interesting and important ways. The articles in the special issue on ‘Strategies in Transition Economies: Challenging the Conventional Wisdom’ published in early 2005, for example, provide an illustration of the kind of approach to consider (Wright et al., 2005).

Under-developed papers represent another category subject to editorial rejection. Lack of development may relate to issues of framing and contribution, scope, thoroughness and completeness of conceptual arguments, nature and rigour of the research design, analysis, and conclusions. Potentially good ideas may not get beyond editorial review because the manuscript has not been put through necessary and developmental processes. We would strongly recommend, for example, that authors obtain feedback from colleagues prior to submission.

Finally, it is important that authors take care in the presentation details. A surprising number of papers come to us with too many typographical and grammatical errors, the 'track changes' feature left on (including comments from authors!), inappropriate structure and section headings, lack of flow in expression and argument, no abstract, missing references, missing or unclear tables and figures, no page numbers, author-identifying information embedded in the text or file, and figures and tables submitted separately from the manuscript (one file plus cover letter only, please). Lack of care in preparing and presenting a paper may unintentionally signal poor substantive quality. We would recommend that authors print out and read hard copies of their papers before submission. For those for whom English is not their first language, we recommend considering a native English speaker to edit the manuscript. Notes to Authors are printed in the back of every issue. These give detailed guidelines on how an article should be formatted prior to submission. The guidelines are also available on the web at <http://www.blackwellpublishing.com/submit.asp?ref=0022-2380>.

Whilst the desk rejection figure may appear high, it is not out of line with other top quality high impact journals. Furthermore, filtering articles at this stage means that we do not overload our much-valued reviewers with articles that they themselves would not send out for review. It also means that we can focus our efforts and resources on those articles that exhibit the greatest potential to make a substantial contribution to the literature.

Comments Following Review

If a decision is taken to send a paper out to review, *JMS* practice is to seek the opinions of three experts in the particular area who are able to comment on the topic, the theory, the method and the extent and nature of contribution (a list of all people who reviewed for the Journal in 2005 follows this article). The average time to take a first decision, including both editorial rejections and papers sent out for review, was 57 days over the three years 2003–05. Following an initial round of comments from reviewers, approximately a further 30 per cent of papers are rejected. After further rounds of review (rarely more than three), the Journal has accepted on average in the last three years a little under 10 per cent of papers submitted.

Table I. Generic reasons identified for rejecting an article, 2003–04

<i>Reason</i>	<i>Number of manuscripts</i>	<i>%</i>
Lack of contribution	248	92
Failure to develop a theoretical contribution	205	76
Fatal flaws in the methods	189	70
Deficiencies in the analysis	156	58

Note: Percentages sum to more than 100% because typically there are multiple reasons for rejecting an article. Based on a sample of 270 papers.

Whether a paper is rejected or a revision is invited, copies of the reviews together with our editorial letter are sent to both authors and reviewers. Ensuring that the reviewers have an opportunity to read all the information we receive enables them to appreciate the context for any subsequent revision and also to benefit from seeing how others approach the article and reviewing. We also wish to be transparent in our decision making and encourage reviewers to discuss our decisions with us. Our overall intention is that the reviewing process should be developmental for both authors and reviewers.

The editorial letter synthesizes the main themes among the three reviewers' comments and provides additional comment based on the editor's own reading of the paper in order to provide guidance as to the way(s) forward. While there may be a need for major changes, we try to make a judgement about the feasibility of any changes before we invite a revision.

Table I identifies the major deficiencies accounting for the rejection of 270 papers between 2003 and 2004. This table indicates not only that papers generally suffered from more than one fatal flaw, but also that these problems were related to the following four general factors:

- In nearly all the articles, the contribution to existing literature is either not evident or is marginal. Authors often have not identified the particular gap in the prior literature that they wish to fill. An article may also be written in such a way that several potential contributions are claimed. In many of these cases, there is a lack of clarity about the focus of the paper. Related to this, reviewers frequently raise the 'so what' question. How does the article take us beyond what is already known? There are also occasions when reviewers argue that the contribution is not novel. Finally, reviewers frequently note that the contribution lacks sufficient significance for publication in this journal.
- The second major theme in these reasons for rejection is that the article does not make a *theoretical* contribution – either in terms of developing and testing new hypotheses or by developing or extending our conceptual understanding

of a phenomenon. Such papers are often overly-descriptive and fail to provide explanations for the observed relationships between variables or patterns in the phenomena being described.

- In many rejected papers, the research design is either fundamentally flawed or inappropriate for the research question. This may mean, for example, that: the sample frame is inappropriate, the constructs and measures are inadequately operationalized, the inter-relationships between constructs are not specified, there is divergence between the measures employed and the hypotheses or model. In quantitative studies, particular problems may arise in using datasets designed for other purposes than those of the submission or from cutting the data too finely so that it overlaps with other work either published or under submission.

Qualitative studies should also be carefully designed with a theoretical question in mind. One of the most common design flaws in this kind of study is the use of a case to illustrate or apply an established theory. Although some journals publish such descriptive case studies, we usually expect new theoretical insights to arise from the analysis of qualitative data.

- Finally, whether the paper is qualitative or quantitative, it may be rejected because there are fundamental problems in how the data is analysed. This relates primarily to the use of inappropriate or inadequate methods given the research question.

Not all papers where we invite a revision successfully make it through the process. In some cases, authors may decide that they are unable to meet reviewers' requests and withdraw the paper. Where authors resubmit a paper, however, it is critical that they seek to address fully the reviewers' comments. For this reason, we ask all authors to provide a detailed response to each point raised by the editor and the reviewers. Experience suggests that this document can speed-up the review process by providing reviewers with a guide back into the paper and articulating the reasoning underpinning the revisions.

Acceptance for Publication

When a paper is nearing acceptance, it is circulated to the other General Editors for developmental comments. We believe this step plays an important role in maintaining consistency among editors.

Once a paper is accepted, the lead-time to publication is now about one year. The editors are aware of the importance of timely publication and keep a close eye on the lead-time to publication. We occasionally vary our annual page budget in order to keep publication times down. Final proof pages are made available to authors prior to publication in pdf format for circulation to key contacts. From May 2006, forthcoming papers will be published via 'Online Early' and available

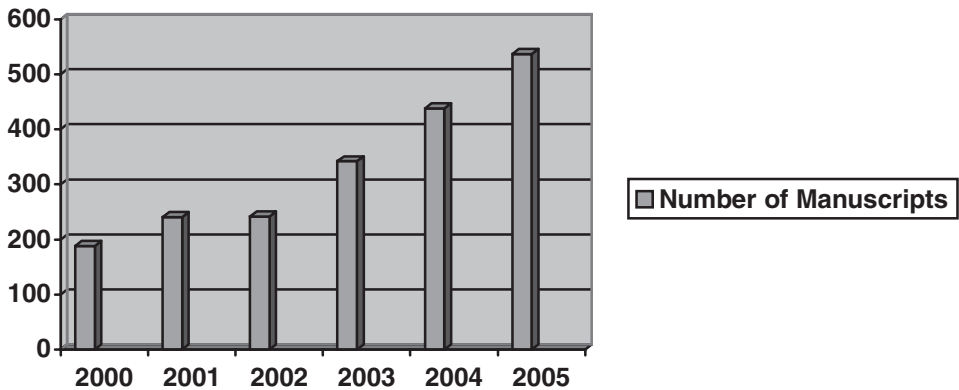


Figure 2. The trend in submissions to *Journal of Management Studies*, 2000–05

through the *JMS* website (<http://www.blackwellpublishing.com/jms>) and Blackwell Synergy (<http://www.blackwell-synergy.com>) journal website. ‘Online Early’ articles are finished, peer-reviewed and will be available online before the print issue is published, enabling readers to access information faster.

LOOKING FORWARD

Over the last three years, we believe that *JMS* has enhanced significantly its reputation as a vibrant, cutting-edge, high quality international journal. The turnaround time and quality of reviewer comments ranks among the best in the business. We are very grateful to the support of the Editorial Board Members and hundreds of reviewers who provide timely and constructive feedback.

JMS has experienced a remarkable increase in submissions over the past three years. From 242 submissions for the six regular issues of the Journal in 2002, numbers have grown to 537 at the end of 2005, representing an overall increase of 222 per cent. Over the last six years, submissions have increased almost threefold (Figure 2). The increasing popularity of the Journal with authors is partly a result of the timeliness and quality of the review process, but also relates to efforts we and Blackwell have made to increase the visibility, and availability of the Journal internationally. Over the past three years, *JMS*’s impact factor in the ISI management ranking has increased from 0.856 in 2002 to 1.180 in 2004. As a consequence, *JMS* has moved from 27th to 19th position in the ISI management category.

It is critical not simply to ensure the quality of the reviewing process and content of the Journal, but also that articles, once published, are read by the largest possible community. Access to the journal has been expanded greatly through subscriptions to paper copy and electronic bibliographic databases. Readership and use of the Journal has increased significantly. Indeed, a little under 284,000 *JMS* articles were

Table II. Countries and areas of origin for submissions to *Journal of Management Studies* in 2005

<i>Country</i>	<i>Percentage of submissions</i>
UK	28.5
USA and Canada	25.7
Europe (continental)	
Spain	6.5
Netherlands	4.5
Scandinavia	5.0
Other Europe	7.8
Asia	
China	2.1
Hong Kong	3.0
Taiwan	4.8
Other Asia	4.3
Australia and New Zealand	4.8
Rest of World (Africa, Middle East and South America)	3.0

Note: Total number of submissions is 537.

downloaded electronically from Blackwell Synergy in 2005. With easier access to the content of the *Journal*, we are attracting submissions from an ever-wider international base (Table II). While the UK and North America still represent the largest geographies for submissions, we have experienced a considerable increase from Asia, Continental Europe and Australasia.

As we explained in an editorial published in December 2003 (Clark and Wright, 2003), recent changes have been made to position the journal for the future. These changes – especially electronic submission – have meant that, despite substantial growth, we have been able to offer an improved service to both authors and reviewers.

This year, we are inaugurating best paper and best reviewer prizes. These prizes relate to papers published in Volume 42 and for reviews completed in 2005. The Best Paper award was decided by a vote of the editorial board, and the Best Reviewer award has been decided by the editors. Prizes will be announced and presented at the editorial board meeting during the Annual Meeting of Academy of Management in August 2006.

The Point–Counterpoint debates section was launched in 2004. Previous debates over the last two years have included the Future of the Business School (Pfeffer and Fong, 2004), Executive Remuneration (Bruce, Buck and Main, 2005), Theory and Context, Corporate Governance and Threshold Firms: Agency versus Knowledge (Zahra and Filatotchev, 2004), Edith Penrose and the Resource Based View of Strategic Management (Kor and Mahoney, 2004), Offshore Outsourcing

(Farrell, 2005), and Communities of Practice (Roberts, 2006). Forthcoming debates include: Quantitative and Qualitative Research Methods, The Dynamics of Cooperation, The Peer Review Process, and Global Strategy.

Special issues published during our editorship include Micro Strategy and Strategizing: Towards an Activity-Based View (Johnson, Melin and Whittington, 2003), The Changing Multinational Firm (Morgan and Whitley, 2003), Speaking Up, Remaining Silent: The Dynamics of Voice and Silence in Organizations (Wolfe Morrison and Milliken, 2003), Controversies and Continuities in Management Studies: Essays in Honour of Karen Legge (Clark, 2004), Strategy Research in Emerging Economies: Challenging the Conventional Wisdom (Wright, Filatotchev, Hoskisson and Peng, 2005), and Manufactured Authenticity and Creative Voice in Cultural Industries (Jones, Anand and Alvarez, 2005). Forthcoming Special Issues include: Risk and Regulation; Why Do Entrepreneurial Firms Exist?; Managerial Dimensions of Organizational Health; The Adoption of Promising Practices; Management Knowledge in Action; Inter-Organizational Knowledge Transfer; Field-Configuring Events as Structuring Mechanisms; Research and Technological Commercialization; Learning from Rare Events: Business History; and the Management of Family Firms. Anyone wishing to submit a special issue proposal should contact Jo Brudenell at the Editorial Office who can supply our Guidelines for Special Issue Proposals.

We have also overhauled the Review section of the Journal under the editorship of Brad Jackson. Forthcoming reviews of book collections include areas such as International Management and Organization, The Organization and Disorganization of Organization Studies, and Strategic Management and Corporate Governance. Please contact Brad via the Editorial Office if you would like to write a Review around a themed group of recently published books.

The Review section is also being extended to include literature review articles covering topical and emerging areas. Forthcoming review articles include Entrepreneurship and Capabilities, Business Groups, and Asian Management Research. Please contact the General Editors if you would like to propose a theme for this type of review. The editorial board was reconstructed at the end of 2003 and now has a more active role. We continue to review its composition and from time to time will make further appointments as the need arises. We would like to thank wholeheartedly both the editorial board and the ad hoc reviewers for their service to the journal.

We would also like to thank Jo Brudenell and Sarah Xiao for their extremely efficient running of the *JMS* Editorial Office. They are the outward face of the editorial team of the Journal, and we are very grateful for the many positive comments the office receives from authors and reviewers.

We anticipate appointing associate editors later in 2006. These appointments are needed to cope with increasing editorial workloads and to help deepen the editorial expertise. We look forward to expanding the *JMS* editorial team in this way and hope the result will be even faster turnaround times and better quality reviews.

Finally, over the past three years, through the charity which oversees the Editorial Management of the Journal – the Society for the Advancement of Management Studies (SAMS) – a number of initiatives have been developed to build of capacity in management research. These initiatives include scholarships for doctoral students to attend a range of international conferences, including doctoral workshops at the Strategic Management Society and the International Conference on Information Systems. Again, please contact the Editorial Office if you would like further information on these activities.

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